

VILLAGE LIFE

Most Nigerians are born and die in the same village and think of it as home even if they move to a big city. Most of the villagers work as farmers, although each village usually has a traditional doctor, blacksmith, and carpenter. Villagers are almost self-sufficient, growing much of their own food, building their own houses, weaving cloth for clothes, and making pots for cooking. Anything they cannot make, they buy with money earned by selling goods in the local market.



MOVING TO THE CITY

Many young Nigerians leave their villages for a few years and move to a city. They go to study, or to earn money that they can send back to their families when profits from farming are low. This money may be used to buy food or books for a child going to school. Once the "migrants" have finished their studies or saved up enough money, they return home to their villages.

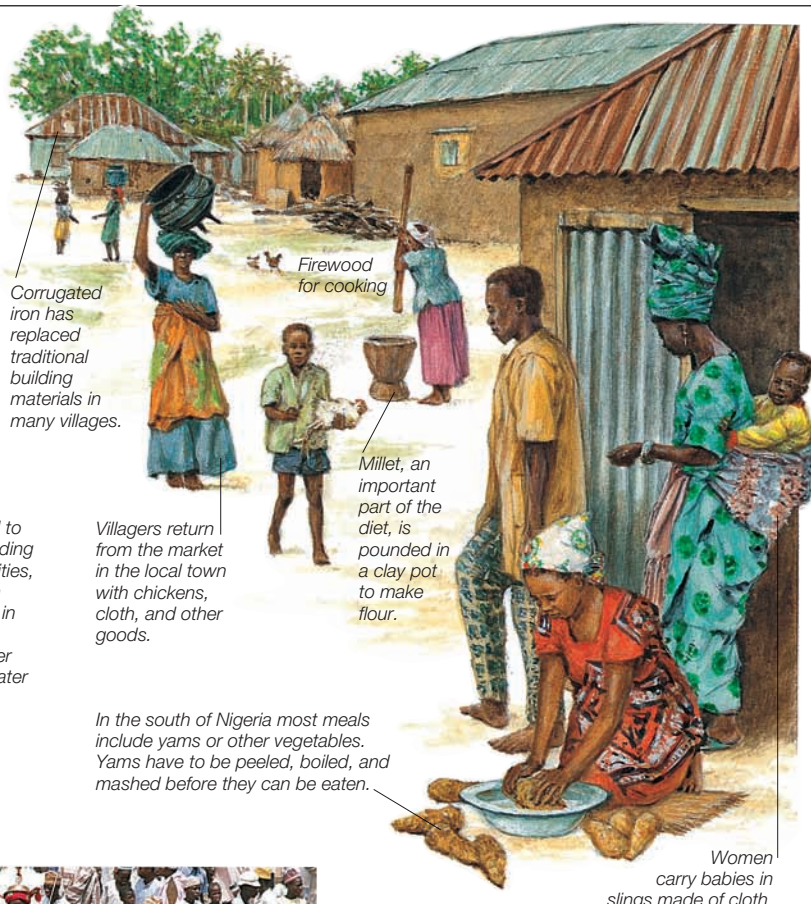


One of the main dyes is indigo, a blue color produced by pulping the leaves of the indigo vine.

DYEING

The Yoruba people of southwestern Nigeria are skilled cloth dyers, making intricate patterns from a range of natural dyes. The cloth is usually dyed in earthenware pots, although the

Hausa people in the northern city of Kano use large pits in the ground lined with a local cement.



Corrugated iron has replaced traditional building materials in many villages.

Firewood for cooking

Millet, an important part of the diet, is pounded in a clay pot to make flour.

Villagers return from the market in the local town with chickens, cloth, and other goods.

In the south of Nigeria most meals include yams or other vegetables. Yams have to be peeled, boiled, and mashed before they can be eaten.

Women carry babies in slings made of cloth.



RELIGION

Nigeria is divided in its religious beliefs. In the north, people follow Islam, which was introduced by Arab traders from across the Sahara Desert during the 11th century. Religious festivals, such as this Sallah procession to mark the end of Ramadan (the Islamic month of fasting), are important local events. Five hundred years later, European merchants brought Christianity into the south. Many Nigerians, however, still follow traditional African religions.

BENIN

SQUASHED UP AGAINST THE WESTERN border of Nigeria, Benin is a long, thin country that stretches north from its narrow Atlantic Ocean coastline to the Niger River. Originally called Dahomey (it was renamed Benin in 1975), the country gained its independence from France in 1960. Since then Benin has had a series of military governments and been a one-party state. In 1990 it became the first African nation to move from one-party rule to a multiparty democracy. Although it is a poor country, Benin has a growing economy based on agricultural products such as cotton, cocoa, and coffee.



COASTAL REGIONS

For centuries, the inhabitants of stilt houses like these along the shores of Lake Ganvie have made their living from fishing. But many former lakes and lagoons have become partly silted up, and many of the fishermen have had to take up sea fishing or move to the towns to find work.

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